COMPARATIVE DEVELOPMENT EXPERIENCES

OF INDIA AND ITS NEIGHBOURS | REVISION NOTES

1. WHY COMPARE?

- This Class XII chapter compares the development paths of India, China and Pakistan. They used different institutions and policies, so their economic and social outcomes differ.
- India and Pakistan became independent in 1947; the People's Republic of China was established in 1949.
- Planning began in India in 1951, China in 1953 and Pakistan in 1956. The starting periods were similar, but the strategies and timing of reforms were not.

2. DEVELOPMENT STRATEGIES

INDIA

- Mixed economy: both public and private sectors operate. Five-Year Plans began in 1951.
- Early strategy stressed public investment, heavy industry and import substitution; the Green Revolution raised food-grain production.
- In 1991, economic reforms introduced liberalisation, privatisation and globalisation (LPG), expanding competition and links with world markets.

CHINA

- After 1949, China followed socialist planning, land reforms and collectivisation.
- Great Leap Forward (1958): communes were created and rapid industrial and agricultural growth was targeted; the campaign caused severe disruption.
- Cultural Revolution (1966–76) disrupted education and economic activity.
- From 1978, reforms gradually gave farm households more responsibility, increased enterprise autonomy, and encouraged foreign trade and investment. Special Economic Zones (SEZs) helped attract investment.

PAKISTAN

- Followed a mixed-economy path, with an important role for private enterprise in many periods.
- The Green Revolution and mechanisation increased agricultural output.
- Some industries were nationalised in the 1970s; later policies shifted towards denationalisation and market-oriented reforms.
- Worker remittances and foreign assistance supported growth in some periods, while performance varied over time.

QUICK TIMELINE

1951	India: planning	**1953**	China: planning
1956	Pakistan: planning	**1958**	China: Great Leap Forward
1966–76	Cultural Revolution	**1978**	China: reforms
1991	India: LPG reforms		

REMEMBER

China's reforms began in 1978; India's major liberalisation reforms began in 1991. Do not mix up these dates.

COMPARISON, OUTCOMES & EXAM POINTS

INDIA • CHINA • PAKISTAN

3. COMPARATIVE DEVELOPMENT OUTCOMES

Economic growth

- China recorded especially rapid and sustained growth after its 1978 reforms. India's growth accelerated after 1991. Pakistan's growth record has been more variable across periods.

Structure of production

- Services contribute a large share of India's GDP; China built a powerful manufacturing and export base. Agriculture remains important for employment in all three countries.

Population trends

- China's one-child policy was introduced in 1979 (historical textbook reference) and helped lower fertility; population ageing is now a concern. India and Pakistan have younger populations and greater pressure to create jobs.

Human development

- In the textbook comparison, China generally performs better on indicators such as literacy, life expectancy and infant mortality. India has made progress, but outcomes remain uneven; Pakistan's results vary across indicators.

World economy

- China used SEZs, foreign investment and exports to connect with world markets. India benefits from its large domestic market and services exports. Pakistan relied on remittances and external assistance in some periods.

4. WHAT CAN INDIA LEARN?

- Invest consistently in education, public health, skills and research — human capital supports long-term productivity.
- Build reliable infrastructure and institutions, and keep policies predictable while adapting to changing conditions.
- Use trade, technology and investment to improve productivity, while helping workers and smaller firms adjust.
- Make growth inclusive: create jobs, reduce poverty and inequality, support women's participation, and protect the environment.

5. KEY TERMS

- Mixed economy — public and private sectors both play a role.
- Green Revolution — use of improved seeds, irrigation and inputs to raise farm output.
- Great Leap Forward — China's 1958 campaign for rapid industrial and agricultural growth.
- SEZ — Special Economic Zone designed to encourage investment and exports.
- LPG reforms — liberalisation, privatisation and globalisation; India's major reforms began in 1991.

EXAM-READY CONCLUSION

Although the three economies began planned development in broadly similar decades, their strategies and results differed. China's post-1978 reforms led to exceptionally rapid growth; India's post-1991 reforms supported a more service-led economy; Pakistan's performance was more uneven. The comparison highlights the importance of stable policies, human-capital investment, infrastructure and inclusive growth.